

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

BAD NEWS FOR KHABRI

Following its disastrous performance in the Uttar Pradesh assembly election last year, the Congress high command had shunted out state party president Ajay Kumar Lallu, known for his proximity to UP general secretary in-charge **Priyanka Gandhi**. But his successor **Brijlal Khabri** has made no impact either. In the recent local body polls, the party did not win a single mayoral seat, managed just four out of 199 seats in the Nagar Palika chairman polls and 14 out of 544 seats in the Nagar Panchayat chairman polls. The party was also left embarrassed when it ended up with two candidates in Mathura. Khabri wanted his candidate to contest, but Priyanka's core team objected and fielded someone else. Looks like Khabri's days are numbered.

The 'K' Word





Gujarat may not have much of an Opposition given that BJP has 156 out of the 182 seats in the assembly, but some BJP leaders make up for it. So, while **Mansukh Vasava**, the tribal MP from Bharuch, alleged discrepancies in the tendering process for NREGA works in his area to favour particular contractors, Sehra MLA **Jetha Bharwad** alleged sub-standard work by contractors in the Nal se Jal scheme. The red-faced ministers of the respective departments squarely put the blame on the administrators. Given that the Congress barb of the Bommai regime being 'a 40 per cent sarkar' hit home in Karnataka, the Gujarat BJP is asserting that elected representatives are meant to 'audit' implementation, which they are doing effectively.

ADDED DISTINCTION



In the week that the Supreme Court gave a reprieve to his government, Maharashtra chief minister **Eknath Shinde** had another reason to celebrate. He secured his diploma in mass communication and journalism from the Yashwantrao Chavan Maharashtra Open University with distinction (77.25 per cent). Shinde holds a bachelor's degree and a certificate course in human rights from the same varsity. Now that's what you call a well-rounded education.



A Curious Dilemma

Many of the younger Trinamool Congress members revere West Bengal chief minister **Mamata Banerjee** as their mother. Some have even saved her number on their cellphones as Chhoto Ma (younger mom). But since they call her 'Didi', or elder sister, they refrained from paying her a tribute on Mother's Day. It did not stop them, though, from ensuring that Mamata's poem 'Ma', which she penned for the occasion, went viral. This is how it goes:

Jotoi dekhi, jotoi jani
Ma amader ashwasto bani
Ophuronto ma-er Bhalobasha
Amader jogaye praner aasha
(The more we see, the more we know/ Ma is the sound of assurance//Unbounded is her love/ It awakens hope for life)

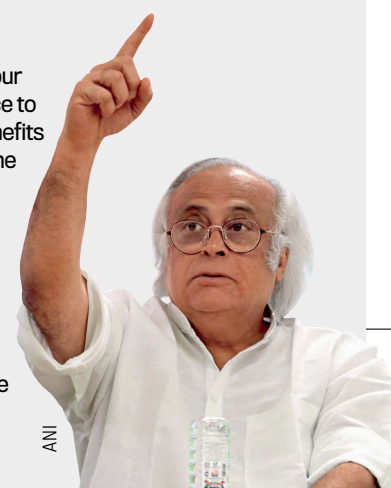
Kaushik Deka with Prashant Srivastava, Jumana Shah, Romita Datta and Dhaval Kulkarni

Trouble-engine Sarkar





Defeat in Karnataka and violence in Manipur have given Opposition parties the chance to mock BJP's 'double-engine sarkar', or the benefits of having a state and central government of the same party. Odisha chief minister **Naveen Patnaik** was first off the block, saying good governance and not 'double-engine' government helps a party win election, seeking to pre-empt the BJP's narrative next year. Congress's **Jairam Ramesh** was next, calling Manipur violence a case of 'double-engine' failure. TMC general secretary **Abhishek Banerjee** had the best jibe, dubbing BJP governments "trouble-engine sarkar".



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